

```
❸ def __str__(self):
    """Return a string representation of the model."""
    return self.text
```

We’ve created a class called `Topic`, which inherits from `Model`—a parent class included in Django that defines a model’s basic functionality. We add two attributes to the `Topic` class: `text` and `date_added`.

The `text` attribute is a `CharField`, a piece of data that’s made up of characters or text ❶. You use `CharField` when you want to store a small amount of text, such as a name, a title, or a city. When we define a `CharField` attribute, we have to tell Django how much space it should reserve in the database. Here we give it a `max_length` of 200 characters, which should be enough to hold most topic names.

The `date_added` attribute is a `DateTimeField`, a piece of data that will record a date and time ❷. We pass the argument `auto_now_add=True`, which tells Django to automatically set this attribute to the current date and time whenever the user creates a new topic.

It’s a good idea to tell Django how you want it to represent an instance of a model. If a model has a `__str__()` method, Django calls that method whenever it needs to generate output referring to an instance of that model. Here we’ve written a `__str__()` method that returns the value assigned to the `text` attribute ❸.

To see the different kinds of fields you can use in a model, see the “Model Field Reference” page at <https://docs.djangoproject.com/en/4.1/ref/models/fields>. You won’t need all the information right now, but it will be extremely useful when you’re developing your own Django projects.

Activating Models

To use our models, we have to tell Django to include our app in the overall project. Open `settings.py` (in the `ll_project` directory); you’ll see a section that tells Django which apps are installed in the project:

```
settings.py --snip--
INSTALLED_APPS = [
    'django.contrib.admin',
    'django.contrib.auth',
    'django.contrib.contenttypes',
    'django.contrib.sessions',
    'django.contrib.messages',
    'django.contrib.staticfiles',
]
--snip--
```

Add our app to this list by modifying `INSTALLED_APPS` so it looks like this:

```
--snip--
INSTALLED_APPS = [
    # My apps.
    'learning_logs',

```